

Examining the Nagorno-Karabakh Conflict in the Post-Cold War Era: An Intercultural Communication Lens

Summary

The conflict in Nagorno-Karabakh begins with the establishment of the region as an autonomous oblast within Azerbaijan's Soviet Socialist Republic. This oblast was majority Armenian, thus when the USSR began to show signs of collapse, the regional legislature passed a resolution declaring its intention to join the Republic of Armenia (*Nagorno-Karabakh Conflict*, 2025). Prior to this, the borders of Nagorno-Karabakh were of less concern, as the USSR was one country, and its citizens could freely travel across regions. However, with the collapse of the Soviet Union, the ethnic tensions between Armenians and Azerbaijanis were reignited and it became more difficult for ethnic Armenians to travel from the Karabakh to Armenia, as they share no borders. In 1988, three years before the USSR fell, the first Nagorno-Karabakh war began. The conflict started as a series of small skirmishes, developing into a full-scale war in 1991. The war resulted in 30,000 casualties and hundreds of thousands of refugees. By 1993, Armenia had gained full control of Nagorno-Karabakh and 20% of the surrounding Azerbaijani territory. The war ended in 1994 with a ceasefire that was formally held until 2020, leaving Nagorno-Karabakh as a de-facto independent state, but it was heavily reliant on Armenia for resources and military support (*Nagorno-Karabakh Conflict*, 2025).

Between 1994 and 2020 there were intermittent clashes between Armenia and Azerbaijan, with drones and special operations providing an ever-present reminder that war could break out at any moment (*Nagorno-Karabakh Conflict*, 2025). The ceasefire formally ended in 2020 with a six-week war. Azerbaijan regained most of the territory it had lost in 1993, leaving Armenia with only a small portion of Karabakh. In the ceasefire that ended this war, a corridor was established between Nagorno-Karabakh and Armenia to transport materials and aid to the ethnic Armenians in the region. This highway, the Lachin corridor, was to be monitored by Russian peacekeepers. However, violence continued to insinuate. In 2022, government-backed Azerbaijani activists blocked the corridor to everyone except for the Red Cross and Russian envoys in protest of environmental degradation due to mining in Nagorno-Karabakh. These protests led to severe shortages and rationing for the people living in the region. Azerbaijan tightened Armenian access to the region with the opening of a checkpoint in April 2023. The protests stopped soon after the checkpoint was put up, leading to speculation that the true intention of the protesters was solely to limit the flow of goods through the corridor. After the checkpoint was put up, Nagorno-Karabakh was effectively cut off from Armenia. The Red Cross wasn't allowed in for fear of smuggling weapons and ethnic Armenians seeking medical care weren't able to pass over to Armenia.

Days after agreeing to re-open the Lachin Corridor in September 2023, Azerbaijan launched an offensive into Nagorno-Karabakh killing around 200 people (*Nagorno-Karabakh Conflict*). Their aim was to neutralize the Armenian military hold in the area. Following this

attack, Azerbaijan reassumed full control of the region and about 100,000 Armenians are documented as having fled (Landgraf & Seferian, 2024). It's estimated that there are somewhere between 50 and 1000 ethnic Armenians remaining in Nagorno-Karabakh. The regional leaders of Nagorno-Karabakh were arrested and are awaiting trial in Baku.

Origins

The protracted conflict in Nagorno-Karabakh is representative of a larger global trend towards longer conflicts that come about due to ethnic, religious, or post-colonial tensions. Nagorno-Karabakh is an example of a division made by an external power that led to an increase in tensions in the wake of the power's collapse. The Karabakh was divided by the USSR along ethnic lines, but there was no connection between the region and Armenia. Following the collapse of the Soviet Union, Armenians' and Azeris' freedom of mobility was limited, producing tensions between the ethnic Armenians and Azeris who lived in Nagorno-Karabakh, a majority Armenian enclave in Azerbaijan.

Upon initial examination of Azeri and Armenian values, it appears as if there would be little justification for conflict between the two nations. Both are traditional, hospitable nations and Azerbaijan's propensity towards religious tolerance should allow the two to coexist well enough. However, the strong ties to the land in Nagorno-Karabakh, which has been under control of both states throughout history, makes the issue of land indivisibility one that supersedes any values that may have limited causes for war in another case.

Types of Conflict

One of the types of conflict at play between Azerbaijan and Armenia is a goal conflict. Goal conflicts occur when there is disagreement about a preferred outcome or end state (Martin & Nakayama, 2022). Because Azerbaijan and Armenia are both trying to exercise sovereignty over the same region, and that is not possible, they are in conflict over incompatible outcomes. The land divisions made by the Soviet Union limited short-term potential for a conflict but didn't anticipate the collapse of the state. The lack of land borders with Armenia exacerbated the tensions between ethnic Armenians and Azeris because travel between Nagorno-Karabakh and Armenia was made more difficult. There is also an issue of land indivisibility, because Nagorno-Karabakh is internationally recognized as part of Azerbaijan, hence under Azeri sovereignty, but there is a large portion of the population who rejects that rule and wants to be independent or under Armenian control.

There is also an affective conflict in Nagorno-Karabakh, where feelings or emotions expressed by the two groups are incompatible (Martin & Nakayama, 2022). Because the Armenian majority in the region didn't want to be ruled by Azerbaijan, their feelings were incompatible with the Azeri national identity which they were subject to. This is expressed through the regional council's interest in becoming part of Armenia following the collapse of the USSR, which wasn't brought to fruition. Now that most ethnic Armenians have left the region,

this conflict may have subsided, but it's still an important factor to explain why the conflict has been fought for so long. Furthermore, because both states feel a strong historical connection to Nagorno-Karabakh, they're unwilling to relinquish their control and sever that connection. Since retaking control of the region, Azerbaijan has been removing Armenian monuments, churches, and cemeteries, indicating that Armenian feelings towards Nagorno-Karabakh are incompatible with Azerbaijanis' and may even be considered a threat (Tangiyan & Gurcov, 2024).

Forces Influencing the Conflict

The main forces in this conflict are social and historical. The ethnic divisions between Armenians and Azeris have created strong senses of national identity that have led to clashes over mutual claim to the same region. Armenians are a majority in Nagorno-Karabakh but a persecuted minority in the rest of Azerbaijan (Commisceo Global Consulting, 2020). The Azeris have limited the ability of Armenians in the Karabakh to access the resources they need to survive, indicating strong social tensions between the two groups. The separation between Armenians and Azeris in the Karabakh, regardless of whether it's voluntary creates an environment wherein tensions can fester. These divisions allow each group to form an opinion about the other that can turn negative. Both groups have strong ties to the region, making it difficult to relinquish, hence, they are going to form negative opinions about the other group who is trying to control the same land (Light, 2025). Therefore, the conflict is exacerbated by the strained relationship of Armenian and Azeri neighbors in Nagorno-Karabakh.

Another force that significantly affects this conflict is the historical one. The basis for this conflict is over 100 years old, thus, there's been a long time for these emotions to fester and for both Armenians and Azeris to feel the conflict first-hand (*Nagorno-Karabakh Conflict*, 2025). This conflict has deeply touched these citizens, to the extent that they aren't willing to give up so quickly. When one thinks about what they've already lost, they need to feel as if it was worth it. These stories become part of the national histories of these nations and drive citizens to continue fighting, working towards a common goal.

National History

The lasting effects of Soviet control can be observed in both countries' grand narratives. The creation of the independent Nagorno-Karabakh Oblast alongside the Azeri one, demonstrated a recognition that there was something unique about the region, which was recognized by both Armenia and Azerbaijan. It would've caused internal issues in the USSR if either the Armenian Oblast or the Azeri one had control of the region, but the Soviet Union only delayed the inevitable, rather than finding a permanent solution. It's possible that following the collapse of the USSR, an internationally recognized independent Nagorno-Karabakh could have been an effective solution to limit violence, but it's unlikely that either Armenia or Azerbaijan would let that persist long term, seeing as they both have such strong ties to the region.

The ties that make the Karabakh so contentious have been integrated into the mythos of Armenia and Azerbaijan. Historically, Armenians refer to the region as Artsakh, and it was an outpost for them against Turkic conquest (Mnatsakanyan, 2020). Today, fighting for Artsakh has become such a pivotal part of Armenian identity. There was a longstanding Armenian community there, which no longer exists, making it an important trauma point in Armenian national identity. Nearly everyone in Armenia knows someone who's been killed fighting in one of the Nagorno-Karabakh wars or skirmishes. Thus, the national history continues to be enforced by every battle that is fought.

For Azeris, Nagorno-Karabakh is viewed as the birthplace of their identity (Mnatsakanyan, 2020). The poets, musicians, and arts that have come out of this region have irrevocably influenced Azerbaijani culture to the extent that they are unwilling to relinquish their claim to that land. It's not ingrained in their national history as the last stronghold of their culture, but rather the place where they became Azeri, rather than just Turkic. Therefore, Azerbaijanis have a very different relationship with Nagorno-Karabakh than Armenians do, but one that's similarly integrated into their national history. By better understanding these narratives and how they connect the people to the place, it becomes more apparent why both groups are willing to fight so diligently for the same piece of land.

Separation as a Hinderance

Separation is "a type of cultural adaptation in which an individual retains his or her original culture, while interacting minimally with other groups" (Martin and Nakayama, 2022). Separation can be either voluntary or involuntary, with involuntary separation being classified as segregation. In Nagorno-Karabakh, the Armenian population voluntarily separated themselves from the Azeri population, to preserve their traditions and culture. If the Armenians in Nagorno-Karabakh were interested in integrating into Azeri society fully, they would be welcome (Edwards, 2023). However, the cultural differences between the two groups and sense of nationalism that Armenians in Nagorno-Karabakh have, separates them from their Azeri neighbors.

While based off the similar values of both groups, there appears to be no significant proclivity to their cooperation, there's also no strong factor bringing them together other than conflict or its resolution. If the main reason for Armenians and Azeris to interact is to resolve the conflict, they aren't going to interact. There needs to be something common between the groups or some concession that needs to be made by them both to come together. If they could come to some sort of consensus, honoring their own cultures, but understanding that in Nagorno-Karabakh they need to work together (Martin and Nakayama, 2022). It's possible that a solution could be achieved in a more expedited manner than otherwise.

Improving Relations

The contact hypothesis argues that communication between groups can be improved solely through the facilitation of spaces which allow them to interact with each other (Martin and Nakayama, 2022). There are certain conditions which must be fulfilled to optimize for success, such as ensuring that group members have equal status, cooperation should be maximized and competition minimized, and ensuring that the contact is voluntary, but this framework offers the potential to build a path forward for Armenians and Azeris in collaboration with one another.

Facilitated conversations have been shown to be effective in combatting the mutual hatred of Armenians and Azerbaijanis, providing them with a deeper understanding of one another. An example of this is a Facebook group called Caucasus Crossroads (Kucera, 2021). This moderated group aims to bring together Armenians and Azeris who have a peace-oriented outlook. They learn about one another's culture, share photos, and create connections that they might not have been able to in real life. This method isn't without its limitations, however. There have been multiple iterations of this group due to conversation getting derailed towards lashing out, demonstrating the importance of facilitation. Ultimately though, this provides a way for people to overcome their initial mindset of fear and understand that there are people on the other side of the conflict as well, breaking down a huge barrier to communication.

Another effective use of the contact hypothesis is through the organization Bright Garden Voices, "bright garden" coming from the most widely accepted translation of Nagorno-Karabakh (Kucera, 2021). This organization facilitates Zoom discussions that aim to build bridges between Armenians and Azeris. It's been successful in many ways, but the discussions are usually led by activists and end up quite political, so the participants are told to try and think like average citizens. Furthermore, the discussions are often male dominated, likely a symptom of the value orientation of both societies. Thus, onlookers are often left curious what women from both countries may think about the same ideas.

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